the members of the GRB war room left for home, it was 3.30 am. The next batch was set to take over at 6 am.

This was just another day in the lives of the Congress social media warriors, particularly after the BJY began on September 7. The yatra—a nearly six-month-long foot march from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, covering nearly 3,500 km—is unprecedented in terms of scale and outreach in the post-Independence history of the country. Every day, it generates moments not seen during political events such as election rallies—men and women of all age groups and social strata walking alongside Rahul Gandhi, the face of the Congress, holding his hand, embracing him, even weeping on his shoulder.

Then there is the spectacle of Rahul breaking into a sprint with veteran leaders, matching steps with a dance group, peeling off sugarcane with his teeth or addressing a crowd amidst the pouring rain. Actors, sportspersons, war heroes and social activists—while emphasising their non-partisan stand—have volunteered to join the yatra because they say they believe in the message of unity and love. "Celebrities reached out because they felt the need to speak out against the hate and communal divide gripping the country," says a senior leader associated with organising the BJY. "Rahul Gandhi will reach out to a larger base of people with powerful social voices, inviting them to walk with him."

While the yatra has created a buzz in every state it has crossed—if only for its scale and novelty—it's the social media team which has the demanding task of beaming the BJY's "uniqueness and objective" to millions of mobile handsets, desktops and laptops across India. And that's what three central teams, supported by an external agency, have been doing relentlessly since September 7. Leading the teams is Jairam, who has coined a new credo for the social media wing—ACT (aggressive, cohesive and timely). Separate from the Congress's communication department earlier, the wing has now been put under the supervision of Jairam, who took charge as the communications in-charge in June. "This has brought cohesion and timeliness to the social media unit. With aggression added to the mix, we are getting wonderful results," says Jairam, who has an eight-member team reporting directly to him, in addition to the Shrinate-led 60-member team.

The newfound aggression is visible in the Congress taking on rivals on social media platforms, post by post, troll by troll, on occasion forcing the adversary to retreat. When some BJP leaders, including former Union minister Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, allegedly posted a fake visual of Rahul in which he was supposedly forgiving the two Muslim assailants who killed Kanhaiya Lal, a Hindu tailor in Udaipur, the Congress publicly named and shamed those who posted the video and forced them to delete the same. Lal had expressed support for BJP leader Nupur Sharma who was suspended for her offensive remarks on the Prophet.

And if counterstrike on social media is not enough, the party is quick to resort to legal recourse, filing defamation cases. If the BJP criticised Rahul's photographs with children during the yatra, alleging political use of children, the Congress responded by writing to the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights and the Election Commission about the alleged use of children for campaigning in Gujarat by PM Narendra Modi. The complaint

WHO IS THE MASTER OF TWEETS?

PM Narendra Modi has nearly four times more followers than Rahul Gandhi. Yet the Congress leader gets more engagements from his tweets than those by the PM



NARENDRA MODI
84.5 million

▶ Nov. 1, 2022 - Nov. 21, 2022
214 591 4,419 19,051

▶ Jan. 1, 2019 - Dec. 31, 2021
9,477 33,801*



RAHUL GANDHI
22.1 million

▶ Nov. 1, 2022 - Nov. 21, 2022
55 1,149 8,364 26,788

▶ Jan. 1, 2019 - Dec. 31, 2021
1,835 57,618*

Followers · No. of tweets posted · Average comments · Average retweets · Average likes · Engagements*

Note: Only tweets in English and Hindi are considered. Retweets by the two leaders are not counted

* Sum of retweets, likes and quotes. Includes only tweets they posted, and excluded retweets (or tweets generated by others); *Source: Social Media and Political Leaders: An Exploratory Analysis by Shamika Ravi and Mudit Kapoor*

RAHUL GANDHI VS OTHERS

On multiple social media platforms, four BJP leaders and Arvind Kejriwal have more followers than Rahul. On YouTube, he is next to PM Modi

NARENDRA MODI
84.5 47
71.1 13.3

AMIT SHAH
31.3 15
4.8 0.07

ARVIND KEJRIWAL
26.7 9.2
1.6 0.4

RAJNATH SINGH
23.1 7
1.2 0.04

YOGI ADITYANATH
22.7 7.3
3.7 NA

RAHUL GANDHI
22.1 5.9
2.2 0.9

NB: These leaders are compared because they have the highest social media followers across all parties in India. All figures in millions